



sportspersons. But to truly take Indian sport forward, we need a holistic approach — a vision document, clear planning, and the involvement of all stakeholders: athletes, coaches, researchers, administrators, and writers who shape the sporting ecosystem.

“We are working with both a 10-year and a 25-year vision. By 2047, when India completes 100 years of Independence, the Prime Minister has set the goal of making India a developed nation. Alongside that journey, our target is clear — India must be among the top five sporting nations in the world.”

On the National Sports Policy, Mandaviya stated, “It draws on global best practices but is rooted in our own model. We must learn from the world, but our framework must reflect India’s unique strengths. The policy emphasises good governance, strong infrastructure, the application of sports science, and systematic talent identification and nurturing.”

The Minister stressed that India’s diversity was a strength to be tapped. “At the same time of the year, one

part of our country experiences heavy snowfall in the Himalayas, another faces scorching 45-degree heat in Rajasthan’s deserts, while the South witnesses monsoon rains in Tamil Nadu.

“Nowhere else in the world is there such a range. Talent exists everywhere — in villages, cities, and tribal areas. Our responsibility is to build an ecosystem that gives every talented child a chance.”

He underlined the importance of governance reforms, saying, “Too often, federations spend their energy in disputes rather than focusing on athletes. That is why we introduced the Good Governance Bill, which places the athlete at the centre. Representation of women has also been ensured, because 50 per cent of our society and our athletes are women — their concerns must be heard, their voices must be present in leadership.”

Mandaviya pointed out that more than 30,000 athletes are employed under sports quotas across ministries and state governments. “These jobs were not given merely for routine

duties but to ensure athletes continue to play, develop, and later transition into roles such as coaches. We must also build an academic culture where retired athletes with passion and knowledge of sport can contribute as teachers, mentors, and leaders,” he said, adding that a “league culture is essential to create more competitive platforms within the country.”

He cited grassroots initiatives such as Khelo India and Fit India. “The Sundays on Cycle movement, for example, began with just 250 cycling clubs registering, and now has grown to over 8,000 locations across the country. This proves there is no shortage of passion or ability in India. What our youth need is opportunity, respect, and the right environment to thrive.”

He congratulated *Sportstar* for convening the summit. “The outcomes and insights will be valuable, and we will study them closely. If each of us, in our own sector, works with this commitment, we can place India at the very top and build a truly developed sporting nation.”

